

also become an innovation on its own. And if you stick to the desire to make improvements, you will always come up with something, whether patentable or not.

What would be your advice to innovators who also want to file a patent? Is it only tied in with the organisation they are working with, or can they do it individually or with their academia?

I have never really mulled over whether my innovations can be patented or not because there is no certainty to it. I've always focused on looking at things deeper. If there is a certain problem on which I'm burning a lot of power, I focus on figuring out how it can be solved better. If I come up with something new during that process, then the determination has to occur to find out whether it is patentable or not.

As a company, there are several mechanisms to figure out if you should be patenting something. It is also important to note that when you patent something, you are essentially disclosing that technology to everyone, and then figuring out if there is any way you can hold it from being illegally used. So, while there are a lot of mechanisms, I don't believe that focusing on getting patents is the way to go about it. I've never focused on getting a patent in a specific case because it depends on a lot of factors, and I don't think it's worth worrying about.

Moreover, in an organisation, a lot of your ideas work better when you take an interdisciplinary approach. For instance, in order to increase the number of patents in a structured way, I have participated in a lot of brown-bag sessions where hardware engineers, system engineers, or power engineers would come together and discuss the areas where significant innovations can happen and brainstorm on them. I have seen amazing innovations come up when you bring different disciplines together because if someone working on hardware receives inputs from someone in software, they have an outsider's perspective which gives them an opportunity to make something. So, as you bring these different thought processes together, new ideas emerge which definitely help when someone is trying to innovate.

Patents are the by-products of the improvements you strive to make. You cannot force them because there are no shortcuts. As you focus on these little improvements, it is just something that happens.

How would you define your leadership style?

My management philosophy is grounded in humility (I know that I don't know everything and there's something to learn from everyone), reliability, accountability, integrity, a thirst for learning, and respect for everyone. The technology industry can be a very intense environment, so I seek to inspire, empower, and motivate teams by setting the same standards for myself as I do for my teams and work with a sincere focus to help ensure successful outcomes. Work-life balance starts with all of us enjoying the work we do, and I am always mindful about making the office a fun place to be.

As a leader, is there a way to motivate people within an organisation to focus on improving, or is it left to each individual's ethos? How do you drive it?

There are two things that we do as an organisation. The first is having the mentality of being best in class. When you're best in class, you're always measuring yourself in all vectors like your position among competitors, in terms of customer satisfaction, in operational efficiency, and so on. As a leader, when you follow the mechanism of dissecting what you have done and how you could have done it better, and applying the lessons learnt from it, you have objective and subjective measures that you drive in the organisation that motivates people to follow the same.

We also have a reward mechanism that drives the whole engine of continuous improvement.

I'm a big believer that if you believe in continuous improvement and lessons learnt by measuring yourself in an objective way and trying to find out what you can do to better yourself when you find out that you are not doing your best in any vector.

If you have that attitude of 'we don't rest until we are the best' organisationally, the only way to get there is through continuous improvement, because progress is by and large an incremental step. It is a marathon and not a sprint. You have to keep at it, which is when innovations come up. There can be factors when making a product that might make you doubt the end-result that might occur, but if the consumer wants something, you have to find out how to win over those factors.

I think it is important to institutionalise this thought-process at any level that allows that, and then have the training and an incentive mechanism to enable that.

Generally, the system of organisational promotions is that the higher one goes, the more responsibility one gets. But there are people who really don't want managerial roles but at the same time have the ambition to go higher. What would your advice be to people who are faced with this dilemma of whether they should continue doing what they love or take up this new challenge?

In engineering, I don't think it matters if you're doing a managerial role or a role where you are leading projects, you still have to work as a team. You have to be updated with the technology. You need to have the ability to dial down to one-foot level of detail, should there be a requirement, and also dial up to a thousand-feet level. No one person can make an engineering product. A software developer or an ASIC designer may have the technical knowledge to develop a product but may be leading a team of 10-40 people to do it. It is a technical execution, but it does require motivating the team to come together and work. There is no getting around the fact that you have to work as a team and learn how to execute it together.

These qualities are needed in engineering because engineering decisions are always about trade-offs. I have realised that there is no one formula that can work when you're trying to find a solution to a problem. You're always trying to find a solution in the constraints of time, schedule, cost, etc. You cannot always put in a formula and expect a unique answer because a unique answer is a constraint. So, as an engineer, if you have an idea, you have to convince your team. You need to have the ability to communicate and convince. Teamwork and leadership is part and parcel of working in engineering.

In any technology company, you have a technical ladder and a management ladder that you can grow in. But even as you grow on your technical ladder, when they give you a product, you are still expected to run with a team of people. You may not be managing them, but you will still have to motivate them, figure out how to divide the task, and make sure that you hand over something to team members that best aligns with their skills.

Now, what comes in the managerial ladder is that when you manage people directly, you are also responsible for their career development. It is not just about managing projects when you're managing people, it is also about taking care of their dreams and their aspirations because they have entrusted that